



Focus on the basics: After cementing his place in India's squad midway through the last decade, Harmeet started focusing on enhancing his skills. K. MURALI KUMAR

becoming an Olympian. Pat comes the reply, "Soon after we won the World Junior Team Championship bronze."

The trio of Harmeet, Soumyajit Ghosh — then the wonder boy of Indian table tennis — and G. Sathiyam had started idolising Sharath and aspiring to follow in his footsteps by then. While Ghosh had all but assured himself a ticket to London — the only Olympics Sharath failed to make the cut for since 2004 — Harmeet wasn't thinking so big.

"I was young, but Ghosh (Ghosh's nickname) was confident of qualifying for the Olympics. It took me some time to realise I could get there too, and around 2013, I really set my eyes on Olympic qualification. I had two near-misses for Rio and Tokyo, but that made me a better table tennis player," he says.

After cementing his place in India's squad midway through the last decade, Harmeet started focusing on enhancing his skills. He realised he needed to improve his short game, so he worked on his flicks during his training stints in Germany. This resulted in him

playing an integral role in India's historic team championship bronze at the 2018 Asian Games and gold medals at the Commonwealth Games.

Sharath admits that after failing to qualify as a team for Tokyo, Harmeet was very determined to help make it happen. Over the last three years, he emerged as India's highest-ranked men's singles paddler in the world, overtaking Sathiyam and Sharath for almost a year.

One cannot help but ask whether qualifying for the team event for the first time matters the most to him or if it's his qualification as one of only two men's singles entries from India.

"For me, the most important thing is representing the country at the Olympics, that too with Sharath bhaiya as India's flag-bearer.

Definitely, everybody has a personal preference, but for me, what matters the most is I will remember representing India in the Olympics."

For every sports fanatic — let alone an athlete — the Olympics is associated with childhood memories. Harmeet is no exception. But his obsession with table tennis reflects in his early Olympic memories as well.

"It was 2000 when I saw Chetan Baboor's picture in action. It was just a picture in a newspaper. Then in 2004, I followed Sharath Kamal. I don't remember the result, but I think he played against a Spanish

player," he says.

"And then in 2008, I followed everything. I remember Abhinav Bindra winning the gold and Vijender Singh winning the (bronze) medal. From then on, I have been following everything."

Everyone entering the Olympic village for the first time has a wishlist of things to do, both inside and outside the arena. Meeting idols, not necessarily from their own discipline, is often a main agenda. Ask Harmeet which athlete he is desperate to meet, and his eyes light up.

"Rafael Nadal," he says. "It might be his last Olympics, so I would like to meet him. I've followed him since he won his first French Open title. I didn't like Federer's domination much at the time; I wanted someone to challenge him. My father liked Federer a lot, and when I saw Nadal, I liked his fighting spirit and never-give-up attitude. I have been following him a lot, so I'd like to meet him in Paris."

It may be Nadal's last Olympics, but Harmeet will definitely revel in his first. And if he can play a stellar role and help India make it a memorable team championship debut by advancing past the initial hurdle, he would all but ensure that Paris won't be his only Olympic appearance.

Let the celebrations begin in July, also Harmeet's birth month, and extend for months thereafter!